490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 14 OF 26

Saul, David, and a Forever King

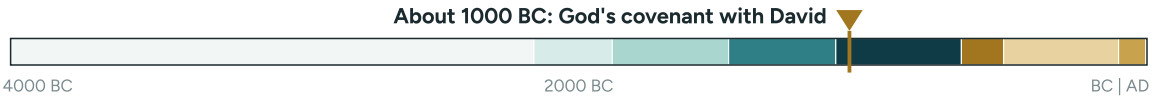
1 Samuel 8; 15–17; 2 Samuel 7; 11–12



David S. Jones

October 18, 2026

YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 14



Introduction: Give Us a King

Judges ended with a cry: "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes" (Judg. 21:25). In 1 and 2 Samuel, Israel finally gets kings. The first one looks perfect and falls apart. The second one is a shepherd boy nobody expected, a man after God's own heart, who also commits one of the most shameful sins in the Bible.

The real center of this lesson is a promise. Around 1000 BC, God made a covenant with David that carries his promise to Abraham forward and narrows it to one royal family: one of David's descendants would sit on a throne that would last forever. From this point on, the Old Testament watches for that King. When the New Testament opens, its very first sentence names him: "The book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the son of David" (Matt. 1:1).

On our timeline, Saul begins to reign around 1050 BC, David reigns from about 1010 to 970 BC, and God makes his covenant with David around 1000 BC.

The Word: Anointed

> **1 Samuel 16:13** *"Then Samuel took the horn of oil and anointed him in the midst of his brothers. And the Spirit of the LORD rushed upon David from that day forward."*

מָשִׁיחַ *(mashiach, "anointed one")*

someone marked out by God with oil for a special task

מָשַׁח (mashach)		Messiah	=	Christ
"to anoint"	→	*from Hebrew*		*from Greek Christos*
To pour oil on someone's head, setting him apart for God's service.		"The LORD's anointed" was Israel's title for its king (1 Sam. 24:6).		The same word in Greek. "Christ" is a title, not a last name.

Payoff: When Andrew told his brother Simon Peter, "We have found the Messiah" (which means Christ), he was saying, "We have found the King" (John 1:41). Every time you say "Jesus Christ," you are saying "Jesus, the anointed King," the one this lesson's story points to.

Part One: A King Like the Nations

Samuel was Israel's last judge and a faithful prophet. But when he grew old and his sons proved corrupt, the elders came with a demand: "Now appoint for us a king to judge us like all the nations" (1 Sam. 8:5). God had planned for Israel to have a king one day (Deut. 17:14–20). The problem was their reason. They wanted to be like everyone else. God told Samuel, "they have not rejected you, but they have rejected me from being king over them" (8:7). Samuel warned them that a king would take their sons and daughters, their best fields, and a tenth of their harvests and flocks. They said, "No! But there shall be a king over us, that we also may be like all the nations" (8:19–20).

So God gave them Saul. He looked the part, "taller than any of the people" (9:2), handsome, and humble at first. But the cracks showed quickly. When Samuel had not arrived by the end of the seven days he had set, Saul grew impatient and offered the sacrifice himself. Samuel walked up just as he finished (13:8–12). Later God commanded him to carry out his judgment on the Amalekites (15:2–3; see Lesson 12), and Saul kept the best of the livestock, then claimed he had obeyed (15:20–21). Samuel's answer has echoed for three thousand years:

> **1 Samuel 15:22–23** *"Has the LORD as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the LORD? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to listen than the fat of rams.... Because you have rejected the word of the LORD, he has also rejected you from being king."*

Saul was a king "like all the nations": impressive on the outside, driven by fear of the people, and always ready with an excuse. God had already said what he would do: "The LORD has sought out a man after his own heart" (13:14).

Part Two: The Shepherd Boy

God sent Samuel to Bethlehem, to the house of a man named Jesse (the grandson of Ruth and Boaz from Lesson 13). Jesse paraded his sons in front of the prophet, starting with the oldest and tallest. Samuel thought, surely this is the one. But God said, "Do not look on his appearance or on the height of his stature, because I have rejected him. For the LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart" (16:7).

Seven sons passed by. None was chosen. Jesse had not even bothered to call the youngest, who was out keeping the sheep. When David came in, God said, "Arise, anoint him, for this is he" (16:12). Samuel poured the oil, "and the Spirit of the LORD rushed upon David from that day forward" (16:13). God's king was a young shepherd his own family overlooked.

Then came Goliath. For forty days the giant of the Philistines strode into the valley and mocked Israel's army, and "Saul and all Israel... were dismayed and greatly afraid" (17:11). David arrived with food for his brothers, heard the giant defy God, and volunteered. He refused Saul's armor and walked out with a staff,

a sling, and five stones.



"The LORD saves not with sword and spear. For the battle is the LORD's" (1 Sam. 17:47).

> **1 Samuel 17:45–47** *"Then David said to the Philistine, 'You come to me with a sword and with a spear and with a javelin, but I come to you in the name of the LORD of hosts, the God of the armies of Israel, whom you have defied.... that all the earth may know that there is a God in Israel, and that all this assembly may know that the LORD saves not with sword and spear. For the battle is the LORD's, and he will give you into our hand.'"*

One stone, and the giant fell. We usually read this story as a lesson about facing our own giants, and there is courage to learn here. But notice where you actually stand in the story. You are not David. You are one of the terrified soldiers on the hillside. Goliath himself set the terms: one man from each side, and the loser's people would serve the winner's (17:8–9). David went out as Israel's representative. When he won, the Philistines ran, and an army that had cowered for forty days rose up and chased an enemy that was already beaten (17:51–52). That is a picture of what another Son of David would one day do for us.

David then spent years running from a jealous Saul. Twice he had the chance to kill him, and twice he refused. "The LORD forbid that I should do this thing to my lord, the LORD's anointed" (24:6). He waited for God to give him the throne in God's time.

Part Three: A House Forever

After Saul died, David became king, first over Judah at Hebron, then over all Israel. He was thirty years old, and he reigned forty years (2 Sam. 5:4). He captured the old fortress city of Jerusalem and made it his capital, "the city of David" (5:7). Then, at peace in his new palace, David had an idea. "See now, I dwell in a house of cedar, but the ark of God dwells in a tent" (7:2). (The ark was the gold-covered chest that stood for God's throne among his people.) He wanted to build God a house, a temple.

That night God answered through the prophet Nathan, and he turned David's idea upside down. David would not build God a house. God would build David a house, a dynasty:

> **2 Samuel 7:12–14, 16** *"When your days are fulfilled and you lie down with your fathers, I will raise up your offspring after you, who shall come from your body, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. I will be to him a father, and he shall be to me a son.... And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."*

Read those promises slowly. An offspring from David's own body. A kingdom God himself would establish. A son who would build God's house. Solomon would build the first one, but his temple would one day fall, and the promise would need a greater Son. A Father-son relationship between God and this King. And a throne that would outlast every dynasty on earth: forever. When this son sinned, God would discipline him, "but my steadfast love will not depart from him, as I took it from Saul" (7:15). This was grace. David had done nothing to earn it. It was the same covenant of grace God made with Abraham, now running through one family toward one King. He went in and sat before the LORD and said, "Who am I, O Lord GOD, and what is my house, that you have brought me thus far?" (7:18).

The Covenant with David (2 Samuel 7) and Its Fulfillment

GOD PROMISED DAVID		FULFILLED IN JESUS
An offspring from your body *2 Sam. 7:12*	→	"Jesus Christ, the son of David" (Matt. 1:1)
I will establish his kingdom *2 Sam. 7:12*	→	"Of his kingdom there will be no end" (Luke 1:33)
He shall build a house for my name *2 Sam. 7:13*	→	Solomon's temple; then Christ's church (Matt. 16:18)
I will be to him a father *2 Sam. 7:14*	→	Applied to Jesus in Hebrews 1:5
Your throne shall be established forever *2 Sam. 7:16*	→	Raised to sit on David's throne (Acts 2:30–32)

"Your throne shall be established forever" (2 Sam. 7:16).

Part Four: The King Falls

If the story stopped there, David would be the hero. It does not stop there. One spring, when kings went to war, David stayed home. From his roof he saw a woman bathing. Her name was Bathsheba, and her husband, Uriah, was one of David's own soldiers, away at the front. "So David sent messengers and took her" (11:4). The king used his power to take what was not his. When she became pregnant, David tried to

cover it up, and when that failed, he arranged for Uriah to be killed in battle. Then he married Bathsheba. The chapter ends with one quiet, terrible line: “But the thing that David had done displeased the LORD” (11:27).

God sent Nathan again, this time with a story. A rich man with huge flocks had a guest to feed, so he stole a poor man’s only lamb, a pet the poor man’s children loved. David was furious: “the man who has done this deserves to die” (12:5). And Nathan said four words:



“You are the man!” (2 Sam. 12:7).

Here is the difference between David and Saul. Saul said “I have sinned” too, but only after insisting he had obeyed and blaming the people, and then he asked Samuel to honor him before the elders (1 Sam. 15:20–30). David made no excuse at all: “I have sinned against the LORD” (12:13). And Nathan answered at once, “The LORD also has put away your sin; you shall not die.” Forgiveness was real and immediate. So were the consequences. The child died, and “the sword shall never depart from your house” (12:10). David’s family was torn apart by violence for the rest of his life. Those consequences were not God taking his forgiveness back. They were a Father’s discipline (Heb. 12:6), exactly what he had promised in 2 Samuel 7:14.

After Nathan confronted him, David wrote Psalm 51, the prayer of every sinner who has ever come home to God: “Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love; according to your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions.... Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me” (Ps. 51:1, 10).

Two Kings, Two Hearts

	SAUL	DAVID
CHOSEN	Tall and impressive (1 Sam. 9:2)	Overlooked shepherd boy (16:11–12)
FACING GOLIATH	Dismayed and afraid (17:11)	"The battle is the LORD's" (17:47)
TOWARD GOD'S ANOINTED	Tried to kill David (18:11; 19:10)	Refused to harm Saul (24:6)
WHEN CONFRONTED	"I have obeyed" (15:20)	"I have sinned against the LORD" (2 Sam. 12:13)

Both sinned. One made excuses; the other confessed. Neither was the King Israel finally needed.

THREAD WATCH

THE LAMB David was a shepherd who would risk his life for his sheep (1 Sam. 17:34–35), and he wrote, "The LORD is my shepherd" (Ps. 23:1). Nathan's parable turned on a stolen lamb. The shepherd-king thread runs straight to the One who said, "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep" (John 10:11).

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE David wanted to build a house where God would dwell among his people. God said David's son would build it. That son was Solomon, and his temple is the subject of Lesson 15. But the promise reaches much further, to a Son who would build a house for God that never falls.

The Turn: The Son of David

David died around 970 BC. His tomb was still there a thousand years later, when Peter preached in Jerusalem: David "both died and was buried, and his tomb is with us to this day" (Acts 2:29). So how could God's promise of a forever throne come true? Peter answered: "Being therefore a prophet, and knowing that God had sworn with an oath to him that he would set one of his descendants on his throne, he foresaw and spoke about the resurrection of the Christ.... This Jesus God raised up" (Acts 2:30–32).

Jesus is the Son of David. He was born in Bethlehem, "the city of David" (Luke 2:4). Before his birth the angel told Mary, "the Lord God will give to him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of his kingdom there will be no end" (Luke 1:32–33). He was anointed with the Spirit of God, who descended on him at his baptism (Acts 10:38), with the Father's voice saying, "This is my beloved Son" (Matt. 3:16–17). Hebrews applies God's promise to David directly to Jesus: "I will be to him a father, and he shall be to me a son" (Heb. 1:5).

Jesus is the better David. David fought Goliath as Israel's champion. Jesus fought our real enemies (sin, death, and the devil) and won the victory for people who could never have won it themselves (Heb. 2:14–15). David was a man after God's heart who still fell into adultery and murder. Jesus was "tempted as we are, yet without sin" (Heb. 4:15). David needed Nathan to say, "You are the man," and then needed forgiveness. Jesus, the sinless King, took the guilt of sinners like David, and like us, on himself at the cross.

And because he rose, his throne really is forever. "Of the increase of his government and of peace there will be no end, on the throne of David and over his kingdom" (Isa. 9:7). The question this lesson leaves you with is the one Israel faced: Who will be your king? You can choose a king like the nations: success, approval, comfort, yourself. Or you can bow to the Son of David, who laid down his life for sinners and turns away no one who comes to him (John 6:37). If you have sinned like David, pray like David. Confess it to God, and trust the King who forgives: "The LORD also has put away your sin."

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the promise.** Read 2 Samuel 7 slowly. Underline every "I will" God says to David.
2. **Check your king.** Where are you, like Israel, wanting to be "like all the nations"? Name one area where you have been following the crowd instead of God.
3. **Obey without excuses.** Saul said, "I have obeyed," when he had not. Is there one thing God has clearly told you to do that you have only half done?
4. **Pray Psalm 51.** Read it each day this week as your own prayer of confession.
5. **Look at the heart.** This week, notice someone others overlook. Treat them the way God treated the shepherd boy.
6. **Memorize 1 Samuel 16:7.** "For the LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."

Before Lesson 15: *Read 1 Kings 3, 8, and 11. Lesson 15 follows Solomon, the son who built God's house, and the first temple in Jerusalem.*

For Discussion

1. Israel wanted a king "like all the nations." Why was that request a rejection of God? Where are you tempted to want to be like everyone else?
2. Saul looked like a king. David looked like a shepherd. What does 1 Samuel 16:7 say about how God chooses, and how we judge?
3. How does it change the Goliath story to see yourself as one of the frightened soldiers rather than as David?
4. In 2 Samuel 7, David wanted to do something for God, and God promised to do something for David. Why does that order matter?

5. Compare how Saul and David each responded when confronted with sin. What separates real repentance from making excuses?
6. David was forgiven immediately but still faced consequences. Why is it good news that God's discipline is a Father's discipline (Heb. 12:6)?
7. Jesus is called "the son of David" in the first verse of the New Testament. What does it mean to you that he is a King whose throne lasts forever?

Sources & For Further Study

- On מָשִׁיחַ and χριστός: Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Hebrew and English Lexicon*; Bauer, Danker, Arndt, and Gingrich (BDAG), s.v.
- On the covenant with David: O. Palmer Robertson, *The Christ of the Covenants*; Westminster Confession of Faith 7.5–7.6. On David as representative champion: Dale Ralph Davis, *1 Samuel: Looking on the Heart*.
- For further reading: Dale Ralph Davis, *2 Samuel: Out of Every Adversity*; Robert D. Bergen, *1, 2 Samuel* (New American Commentary).



David S. Jones

Author of *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting*. He teaches Scripture every week or so at 490.life, serves on the worship teams at Scottsdale Bible Church, and serves in the men's group, The Forge, helping to disciple men and pointing them to Jesus. He coaches and mentors men one-to-one and speaks to churches and men's groups.

© 2026 490 Life Publishing · David S. Jones · Scripture quotations from the ESV · 490.life